

Ethical Concerns for Public Safety in Regards to Gun Control in the US

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Introduction

America has one of the highest rates of gun crime in the world (Gramlich). In 2020, there were over 45,000 deaths caused by firearms in America and it is the leading cause of death for youth populations in the nation (BBC News¹ ; America's Health Ranking²). John Gramlich, a senior writer for the Pew Research Center, wrote that “[the] 2020 total represented a 34% increase from the year before, a 49% increase over five years and a 75% increase over 10 years” (Gramlich). Moreover, from 2020 to 2022, there were over 600 mass shootings annually (Boschma).³ With such horrifying statistics, something must be done about gun violence. One of the suggested methods is stricter enforcement of gun control. However, controversy shrouds this solution as ethical concerns clash against one another on whether or not it would truly solve the issue, and even the possibility of it backfiring. Therefore, it is necessary to analyze the ethics-based reasoning behind gun control and its opposition.

Unqualified, Unwell, or Irresponsible Gun Owners

According to research analyst Katherine Schaeffer, 4 in 10 adults in America live in a household with a gun (Schaeffer).⁴ However, whether or not these individuals are qualified to own a firearm is uncertain. In an investigation conducted by Everytown for Gun Safety it was found that “1 in 9 people arranging to buy a firearm on Armslist.com, the nation’s largest online gun marketplace, are people who cannot legally have firearms”.⁵ Furthermore, they reported that “1.2 million ads offering firearms for sale [...] would not legally require a background check”

¹ BBC News is a well trusted news reporting company under the United Kingdom government.

² America’s Health Ranking is produced by the United Health Foundation, it evaluates data concerning public health, environment, and socioeconomic factors.

³ Janie Boschma is a senior editor for CNN's Visual News team and CNN Politics. She had previously worked as a data journalist for The Atlantic and National Journal, Yomiuri Shimbun, and the Washington Post.

⁴ Katherine Schaeffer is a research analyst for Pew Research Center, a non-partisan organization focused on data-driven social science research.

⁵ Everytown for Gun Safety is a nonprofit organization which advocates for gun control.

(Everytown for Gun Safety). This poses the concern that firearms acquired by unchecked persons may be used without proper training or, more alarmingly, for malicious purposes. However, there is also worry for those who do obtain guns legally, as according to a study conducted by the National Institute of Justice, “77% of those who engaged in mass shootings purchased at least some of their guns legally, while illegal purchases were made by 13% of those committing mass shootings” (NIJ).⁶

Additionally, even in households where the gun owner passes a background check, if the firearm is not stored away from unqualified individuals, accidental or purposeful deaths are a possibility. The National Institute of Justice discovered that even “[firearm] owners who received training [from either military or law enforcements are] no less likely than others to keep guns loaded and unlocked” (Cook & Ludwig).⁷ In a study conducted by David Hemenway and Sara J. Solnick, they “estimate that there were 229 unintentional firearm fatalities of children [in 16 states for an] eight year period” (Hemenway & Solnick).⁸ Additionally, the Sandy Hook Promise organization reported that “68% of gun-related incidents at schools were taken from the home [from] a friend or relative”, this further indicates that firearms are not properly stored in the home (Sandy Hook Promise).⁹ These factors suggest that without limiting the general public’s purchasing of firearms, such patterns of deaths will continue to persist. Therefore, some believe that the most ethical solution is to limit the availability of firearms to only police and militias as, ideally, they would all be trained and sensible.

⁶ The National Institute of Justice is an official organization of the United States government Department of Justice.

⁷ Philip J. Cook and Jens Ludwig wrote this research brief for the U.S. Department of Justice, Office of Justice Programs, National Institute of Justice.

⁸ David Hemenway and Sara J. Solnick are alumni of Harvard School of Public Health and the University of Vermont respectively.

⁹ Sandy Hook Promise is a national nonprofit organization founded and led by several family members whose loved ones were killed at Sandy Hook Elementary School. Their mission is to prevent future gun violence tragedies.

However, should firearms be limited from the public, rates of other types of violent crime may rise. A model analyzing the impact of gun laws found that “marginal gun control increases non-gun crime but reduces gun crime” (Mialon & Wiseman).¹⁰ For instance, although China’s firearm regulation is one of the strictest in the world, the public is still harmed through mass stabbings (Gan & Westcott).¹¹ During June of 2021, “six people were killed and 14 injured after a knife-wielding man stabbed passersby on a pedestrian shopping street [in China]” ; cases such as this bring up the concern that the limitation of firearms may not aid in lowering mass casualty incidents (Gan & Westcott).

Self Defense in Regards to Firearms

Since it is unrealistic to prevent all criminals from accessing firearms, some worry that limiting the public’s access to them may cause the common citizen to be unable to defend themselves against an attacker. According to a 2019 Gallup survey, “gun owners were most likely to cite personal safety or protection as the reason they own a firearm” (Schaeffer). However, when examining the statistics of firearms used in self defense, a different scene is shown. The National Crime Victimization Survey, conducted by the Bureau of Justice Statistics, found that between 2007 to 2011, “there were 14,145 crime incidents in which the victim was present at the incident ; [Less than 0.9% of victims] used a gun to threaten or attack the perpetrator” (Hemenway & Solnick). In a journal written by scholars of criminology and criminal justice, they calculated that from 1987 to 1990, “fewer than 2 victims in 1000 defended themselves with guns” on average (McDowall & Wiersema).¹² Other surveys such as those

¹⁰ Hugo M.Mialon and Thomas Wiseman are both scholars of economics at Emory University and the University of Texas at Austin respectively.

¹¹ Nectar Gan and Ben Westcott wrote this article for CNN, a popular outlet for reliable news stories.

¹² D McDowall and B Wiersema are scholars of the Department of Criminology and Criminal Justice at the University of Maryland. They have worked for the National Library of Medicine, which is an official organization of the United States government.

conducted by the Harvard Injury Control Research Center had similar results, concluding that “far more survey respondents report having been threatened or intimidated with a gun than having used a gun to protect themselves” (Hemenway et al).¹³ Although the possibility of protecting oneself with a firearm exists, more often than not, “criminals face little threat from armed victims”(McDowall & Wiersema).

Furthermore, although many individuals keep their firearms at home with the intent to fend off intruders, it appears that doing so causes more harm than good. A study which analyzed the risk of gun ownership found that “[guns] kept in homes are more likely to be involved in [...] accidental shooting, criminal assault, or suicide attempt than to be used to [...] in self-defense” ; this is supported by other studies such as one conducted for the American Journal of Epidemiology whose findings showed “an association between guns in the home and risk of a violent death” (Kellermann et al¹⁴ ; Dahlberg et al¹⁵). Although the concern of gun control limiting self defense isn’t unwarranted, from these data, it can be concluded that firearms are used for harm rather than self defense by a large margin.

Although the data largely indicate a lack of firearm usage in self defense, it is important to acknowledge that the data surrounding it can be contradictory. For example, Gary Kleck – a widely cited scholar in gun crime analysis papers – calculated “total annual estimates of 999068 and 783000 incidents [of] firearm protection [based on two analyses with certain assumptions]” (McDowall & Wiersema). However, this computation has been criticized by other scholars, such

¹³ David Hemenway, Deborah Azrael, and Matthew Miller are all scholars of Harvard Injury Control Research Center at Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health.

¹⁴ All the authors that contributed to this article – Arthur L. Kellermann, Grant Somes, Frederick P. Rivara, Roberta K. Lee, Joyce G. Banton – have credentials in public health, injury control, or medicine.

¹⁵ Linda L. Dahlberg, Robin M. Ikeda, Marcie-jo Kresnow wrote this report for the American Journal of Epidemiology, a peer-reviewed journal that publishes findings in the field of epidemiology.

as Hemenway, for being an overestimation (The Virginia Center for Public Safety).¹⁶ Therefore, when discussing guns as protection, one must consider the possibility of inaccurate data.

Conclusion

There is not enough progress being made towards reducing gun violence in America given that within the first month of 2023, there have already been more than 50 mass shootings (Gun Violence Archive).¹⁷ As explained by the aforementioned paragraphs, the most ethical solution appears to be to limiting the public's access to firearms by a degree higher than it currently is in order to deter homicides, suicides, and accidental deaths. A method of achieving this is to enforce more and stricter background checks not only to prevent obviously malicious people from accessing firearms, but also straw purchasers – someone who illegally purchases a firearm for another person (ATF).¹⁸ This method has been correlated with positive effects. For instance, a “1995 Connecticut law requiring gun buyers to get permits (which themselves required background checks) was associated with a 40 percent decline in gun homicides and a 15 percent drop in suicides” and a study analyzing the results of “Missouri's 2007 repeal of its permit-to-purchase law” had similar results (Kurtzleben).¹⁹ Additionally, Daniel W. Webster, a researcher for Johns Hopkins Center for Gun Policy and Research, suggested that “being forced to get a permit from law enforcement [may deter straw purchasing]” (Kurtzleben). By applying this solution or those similar to it, specific, qualified people can still have their firearms,

¹⁶ The Virginia Center for Public Safety is a non-profit, non-partisan organization dedicated to the reduction of gun violence in Virginia.

¹⁷ Gun Violence Archive is a non-profit corporation that provides free online public access to accurate information about gun-related violence in the United States.

¹⁸ The Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives is a law enforcement agency in the United States' Department of Justice.

¹⁹ Danielle Kurtzleben is a political correspondent working for NPR's Washington Desk, a credible American nonprofit media organization.

simultaneously, thousands of lives can be saved from the destruction of shootings committed by unqualified individuals.

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